

divine command theory (DCT): eternal moral truths are determined by God's will (not vice versa)

- aka "theological voluntarism"
 - unrestricted DCT: there isn't anything determining God's will when it determines eternal moral truths, it acts completely arbitrarily, and eternal moral truths could have been determined differently
 - restricted DCT: there are eternal truths (e.g. about value) that determine God's will when it determines eternal moral truths, so that God's will doesn't act arbitrarily and eternal moral truths are necessary and immutable
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Euthyphro dilemma: is it that eternal moral truths are determined by God's will, or is it that God's will determined by eternal moral truths?

- in Plato's *Euthyphro* dialogue: is the pious pious because the gods love it, or do the gods love the pious because it is pious?
- dilemma = two horns, where each horn leads to trouble

<u>Horn #1</u>	<u>Horn #2</u>
<i>DCT: eternal moral truths are determined by God's will</i>	<i>God's will is determined by eternal moral truths</i>
<u>problems</u>	<u>problems</u>
- irrationality - anything goes - contingency / mutability - obligating commands - God's goodness - is-ought problem	- sovereignty - omnipotence - freedom of the will - morality without God

egoism: a kind of theory having to do with *self-interest*

- psychological egoism: all human action is ultimately motivated by self-interest alone
 - this doesn't necessarily mean that you always act in your *greatest* self-interest
 - pure altruism, pure malice is psychologically impossible
 - this would reject the possibility of *self-oriented* concerns that aren't *self-interested*: e.g., caring about your reputation after you're dead might be a case in point
- rational egoism: all human action is rational only to the extent that it promotes our self-interest
 - pure altruism may or may not be psychologically possible, but it's certainly irrational
 - the fact that an action will benefit others gives you no *rational* reason to choose it (although it might be argued that you have some *moral* or *aesthetic* reason to choose it)
 - given two actions that will both promote your self-interest, it's irrational to choose the action that you know will promote your self-interest less
- ethical egoism: the content of morality is determined by what promotes our self-interest
 - e.g., keeping promises is right only because it avoids trouble ("honesty is the best policy")
 - the fact that an action will benefit others gives you no *moral* reason to choose it

Evidence for egoism in Hobbes and Mandeville

Hobbes in *Leviathan*:

Sudden glory is the passion which maketh those *grimaces* called LAUGHTER; and is caused either by some sudden act of their own that pleaseth them; or by the apprehension of some deformed thing in another, by comparison whereof they suddenly applaud themselves. And it is incident most to them that are conscious of the fewest abilities in themselves; who are forced to keep themselves in their own favour by observing the imperfections of other men. And therefore much laughter at the defects of others is a sign of pusillanimity. For of great minds one of the proper works is to help and free others from scorn, and compare themselves only with the most able.

On the contrary, *sudden dejection* is the passion that causeth WEeping; and is caused by such accidents as suddenly take away some vehement hope, or some prop of their power: and they are most subject to it that rely principally on helps external, such as are women and children. Therefore, some weep for the loss of friends; others for their unkindness; others for the sudden stop made to their thoughts of revenge, by reconciliation. But in all cases, both laughter and weeping are sudden motions, custom taking them both away. For no man laughs at old jests, or weeps for an old calamity.

[...]

Grief for the calamity of another is PITY; and ariseth from the imagination that the like calamity may befall himself; and therefore is called also COMPASSION, and in the phrase of this present time a FELLOW-FEELING: and therefore for calamity arriving from great wickedness, the best men have the least pity; and for the same calamity, those have least pity that think themselves least obnoxious to the same.

Contempt, or little sense of the calamity of others, is that which men call CRUELTY; proceeding from security of their own fortune. For, that any man should take pleasure in other men's great harms, without other end of his own, I do not conceive it possible. (Ch. VI. 42–3, 46–7)

11.1: "the voluntary actions and inclinations of all men tend, not only to the procuring, but also to the assuring of a contented life, and differ only in the way"

13.3: "their end, which is principally their own conservation, and sometimes their delectation only"

14.8: "Whensoever a man transferreth his right or renounceth it, it is either in consideration of some right reciprocally transferred to himself or for some other good he hopeth for thereby. For it is a voluntary act, and of the voluntary acts of every man the object is some good to himself"

14.12: "When the transferring of right is not mutual, but one of the parties transferreth in hope to gain thereby friendship or service from another (or from his friends), or in hope to gain the reputation of charity or magnanimity, or to deliver his mind from the pain of compassion, or in hope of reward in heaven, this is not contract, but GIFT, FREE-GIFT, GRACE, which words signify one and the same thing."

14.29: "For man by nature chooseth the lesser evil, which is danger of death in resisting, rather than the greater, which is certain and present death in not resisting."

15.4: (The Foole talking) "you may call it injustice, or by what other name you will, yet it can never be against reason, seeing all the

voluntary actions of men tend to the benefit of themselves, and those actions are most reasonable that conduce most to their ends"

15.5: "against reason, that is, against the benefit of [the person deciding whether to keep the covenant]"

15.7: "every man, not only by right, but also by necessity of nature, is supposed to endeavour all he can to obtain that which is necessary for his conservation"

15.31: "every man is presumed to do all things in order to his own benefit"

17.1: humans "naturally love liberty and dominion over others"

17.15: "considering what values men are naturally apt to set upon themselves, what respect they look for from others, and how little they value other men..."

19.9: "every man by nature seeketh his own benefit and promotion"

21.21: "The end of obedience is protection, which, wheresoever a man seeth it, either in his own or in another's sword, nature applieth his obedience to it, and his endeavour to maintain it."

25.2: "the proper object of every man's will is some good to himself" [Latin: "From this it follows that he who commands does this for the sake of his own good, since he demands that his own will be considered a reason. And the object of the will is always some good to him who wills."]

25.4: "to demand right to counsel another argues a will to know his designs, or to gain some other good to himself, which (as I said before) is of every man's will the proper object"

27.8: "when men compare the benefit of their injustice with the harm of their punishment, by necessity of nature they choose that which appeareth best for themselves"

30.11: "nor would there be any reason why any man should desire to have children, or take the care to nourish and instruct them, if they were afterwards to have no other benefit from them than from other men"

Mandeville in *Fable of the Bees* vol. I

"There is no Merit in saving an innocent Babe ready to drop into the Fire: The Action is neither good nor bad, and what Benefit soever the Infant received, we only obliged our selves; for to have seen it fall, and not strove to hinder it, would have caused a Pain, which Self-preservation compell'd us to prevent"

"That we are often asham'd, and blush for others... is nothing else but that sometimes we make the Case of others too nearly our own; so People shriek out when they see others in danger: Whilst we are reflecting with too much earnest on the Effect which such a blameable Action, if it was ours, would produce in us, the Spirits, and consequently the Blood, are insensibly moved after the same manner, as if the Action was our own, and so the same Symptoms must appear."

"All Mothers naturally love their Children: but as this is a Passion, and all Passions center in Self-Love, so it may be subdued by any Superior Passion, to sooth that same Self-Love, which if nothing had interven'd, would have bid her fondle her Offspring."